

FILING CHECKLIST

For: John Doe — Fairfax, VA

Follow these steps to file your Answer with the court. Check off each item as you complete it.

- ☐ **Step 1: Review Your Packet**
Read through all documents. Make sure your name, case number, and all information is correct.
- ☐ **Step 2: Sign the Answer Form**
Sign and date your Answer form where indicated. Use blue or black ink.
- ☐ **Step 3: Make Copies**
Make at least 3 copies of EVERY document in your packet. Keep one copy for yourself.
- ☐ **Step 4: File with the Court Clerk**
Take the original + 2 copies to the courthouse where your case was filed. Ask the clerk to stamp all copies as 'Filed' and keep a stamped copy.
- ☐ **Step 5: Check Filing Fee (or File Fee Waiver)**
Ask the clerk about the filing fee. If you cannot afford it, submit your fee waiver form (included in this packet) at the same time.
- ☐ **Step 6: Serve the Landlord**
You must deliver a copy of your filed Answer to the landlord or their attorney. Keep proof of delivery (certified mail receipt, hand-delivery receipt, or email confirmation).
- ☐ **Step 7: Note Your Deadline**
Your response deadline: You must appear on the return date shown on your summons. Mark this date on your calendar.
- ☐ **Step 8: Prepare for Hearing**
If a hearing is scheduled, bring all your documents, evidence, and your hearing script (included in this packet). Review it beforehand.
- ☐ **Step 9: Attend All Court Dates**
Arrive 15 minutes early. If you miss a court date, the judge may enter a default judgment against you.
- ☐ **Step 10: File Proof of Service**
After serving the landlord, file a Certificate of Service or Proof of Service with the court. The e-filing instructions in this packet explain how.

IMPORTANT: This document is provided for informational purposes only. It is not legal advice. If you need legal advice, contact a licensed attorney. You are responsible for your own case and what you say in court.